The Life You *Choose*

THE MADE REAL BLUEPRINT / STEP 3

Go and change where I am

Do I change my life where I am, or do I move?

A written request for four days, with my notice period, and the first Friday off.

Sam · In 8 weeks

MY FIVE LIGHTS / AS I RECORDED THEM

Money	Papers	People	Place	Plan B
Amber	Green	Green	Green	Green
One full month lived on €2,360, with the rent and the bills paid out of it	Nothing to arrange. Same country, same contract, same address	My sister knows, and my manager has agreed to a meeting	I stay in the flat I know, at the rent I know	Four days is reversible, and the reserve is untouched

The colours are my own answers on the day. Nothing here says that anything is ready.

THE CONDITIONS STILL OPEN

- **Money** — After the first month

  One full month lived on €2,360, with the rent and the bills paid out of it

My first step: Ask my manager for a meeting about a four-day week. In the first week.

02 / MONEY

What the numbers can carry

Monthly costs €2,210

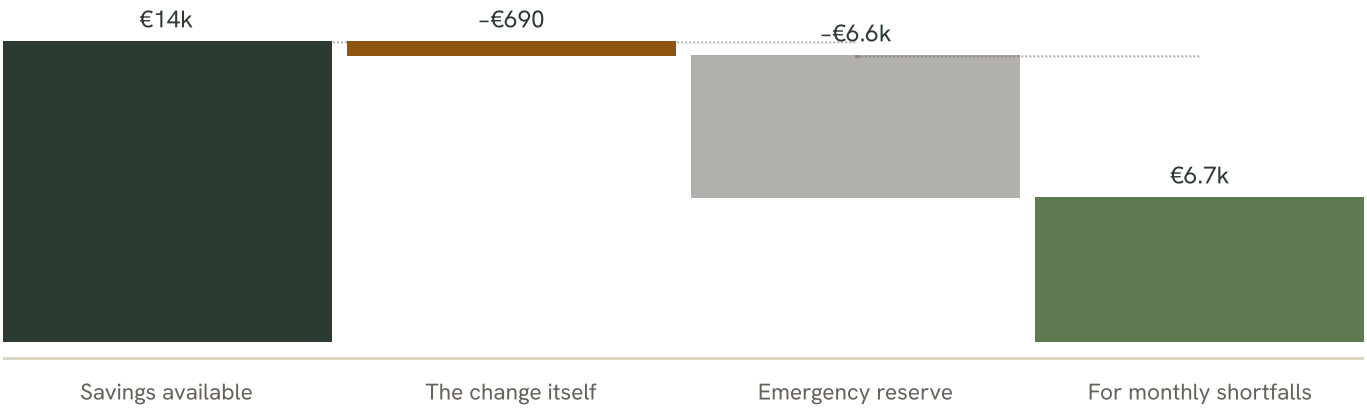
Income I can count on €2,360

€150

left over each month

On the income I can count on today.

HOW €14,000 BECOMES €6,710 TO LIVE ON



6

months I want

If everything costs 30% more: Costs €2,873 and I am €513 short each month. The reserve covers about 13 months. I would go back to five days for a season rather than spend it.

My runway divides the money left to live on (€6,710), not my savings: the reserve and the return fund are kept out of it on purpose. Nothing here is advice; these are my own figures.

RISK AND A WAY BACK

What I will watch

What I want is already here. The four-week test worked on six evenings out of eight. Moving would cost me the people I stay for.

01 **I get the time and fill it with work again**

Warning sign: Two Fridays in a row where I do not leave the house

A standing Friday with my sister, so somebody is expecting me

02 **My manager says no**

Warning sign: The meeting keeps being moved

Keep the two evenings, ask again after six months, one unpaid day a month meanwhile

03 **Four-fifths pay turns out to be tight**

Warning sign: The first month ends with nothing left over

Live on the lower figure for a month before I sign anything

My own judgement of what could go wrong. The warning signs are things I will look for, not predictions.

MY WAY BACK

Keep a home. Protect a return fund.

Not needed. The equivalent is the reserve, and the fact that four days is reversible.

My five-day contract until the four-day one is signed. My reserve of €6,600, untouched.

THE ALTERNATIVE STILL ON THE TABLE

Nothing changes, nothing is risked, and the money stays where it is.

FROM DECISION TO ACTION

The order I will do this in

One full month on four-fifths pay, with the rent and the bills paid out of it.

1

FIRST WEEK

Ask my manager for a meeting

What must be true first: A month of figures I believe

2

FIRST MONTH

Live on four-fifths pay on paper

What must be true first: Last three months of spending in front of me

3

SECOND MONTH

Put the request in writing

What must be true first: A yes in principle

4

THIRD MONTH

Take a corner of a neighbour's allotment

What must be true first: Tools and boots

5

FOURTH MONTH

First Friday outdoors

What must be true first: The change in place

A COMMITMENT I KEEP FOR LATER

I rent, and I keep renting. A four-day week is not the month to take on a mortgage.

LOOK AGAIN / IN 8 WEEKS

A flat no from work with no room in it, or a month on the lower pay that does not add up.

Decided with: Me, with my sister. We agree.

IF I AM STAYING

My change plan

Four days a week in the same job, with Friday outdoors, and two evenings a week that end at six.

In place by the fourth month.

WHAT I KEEP

My job and the people in it, the flat, my sister ten minutes away, and the Thursday market.

THE SMALL TEST I RUN FIRST

Four weeks of evenings that end at six, and one unpaid Friday, before I put the request in writing.

1

FIRST WEEK

Ask my manager for a meeting

What must be true first: Nothing yet. This one is a conversation, not a request

2

FIRST MONTH

Live on four-fifths pay on paper

What must be true first: Last three months of spending in front of me

3

SECOND MONTH

Put the request in writing

What must be true first: A yes in principle

4

THIRD MONTH

Take a corner of a neighbour's allotment

What must be true first: Tools and boots

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FOURTH MONTH

First Friday outdoors

What must be true first: The change in place

IF I AM STAYING

What it rests on, and the way back

MONEY AND BUFFER

€2,360 a month from the fourth month, confirmed, against €2,210 of costs. The buffer stays at €6,600, three months of everything, untouched.

HOURS I DECIDE, BEFORE AND AFTER

About 16 hours a week now. About 26 after the change.

WHO I TELL

My sister first, then my manager, then the team. From my sister I need a standing Friday, so somebody is expecting me.

MY FIRST 90 DAYS

Week one, the meeting. After 30 days, two evenings a week that really end at six. After 90 days, the request agreed and in writing.

WHAT IS STILL UNCERTAIN

What the lower pay does to my pension over ten years. Whether I keep the Friday in January, when it is dark and wet.

MY PLAN B

If four days is refused, I keep the two evenings and ask again after six months, with one unpaid day a month meanwhile. If the lower pay does not add up, I go back to five days for a season rather than spend the reserve.

I look at this again: the third month after the change, and again after a year. Staying is a decision like any other, and this is the plan that goes with it.